Faith was revealed by God to Abraham and was therefore beyond contestation, even if its three major variants, Judaism, Christianity and Islam (in order of appearance!) relied on different texts; and in Muslim belief, God revealed Himself further to Muhammad, who became the definitive Prophet of His Word. Since the word of God cannot be false, all three Semitic religions came to revolve around ideas of absolute truth; they were the only way to reach God, and those who chose other paths were doomed to hellfire or damnation. Many saw it as their duty to show the absolute truth they had found to those who were still in darkness but unaware of the error of their ways. If you resisted their truth, you were wrong and if you were unwilling to correct yourself, you must be either misguided, evil or blind—the only possible explanations for those unable or unwilling to see the truth laid before them by these 'revealed' religions. For this reason it was permissible, for some 'true believers', to convert you to the 'right' path by force or inducement.

Sanatana Dharma, however, saw its adherents engaged in a permanent quest for truth, which was not something revealed from on high by God or a prophet, but something that had to be searched for by prayer, meditation, good conduct and experience, and could well be attained only at the very end of one's life, if at all. Religion is, after all, experience; ideally, it is an experience of God. The *Svetashvatara Upanishad* says: 'God, the maker of All, the great spirit ever seated in the hearts of creatures, is fashioned by the heart, the understanding and the will. They who know that become immortal.' The heart, the understanding and the will each play their part; all are indispensable. This also means that religious experience is personal experience; self-realisation will vary from individual to individual. After all, the Divine, as Radhakrishnan argued, reveals itself to men within the framework of their intimate perceptions and prejudices. The Western faiths largely look outward to the heavens for their revealed truths; the Hindu looks within himself.

A Hindu could live his faith at one or more of several levels: the quotidian, with its temple rituals, religious observances, social customs and good deeds (the path of religious performance); the spiritual, with extensive prayer, meditation, worship of and service to a deity, penance